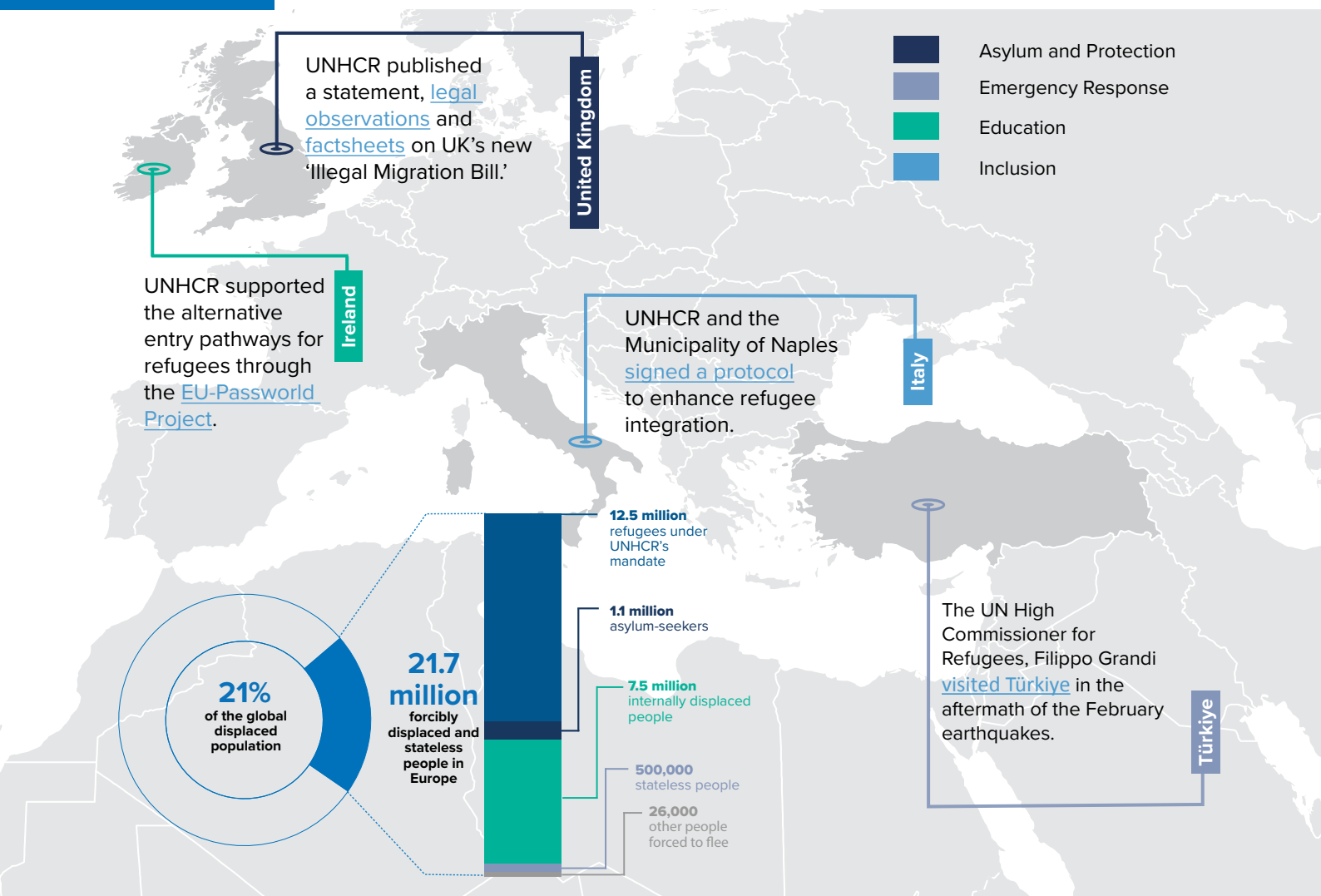


SPOTLIGHT



Source: UNHCR [data finder platform](#) and mid-year statistics data as of 30 June 2022.

References to Kosovo shall be understood to be in the context of Security Council Resolution 1244 (1999). The boundaries and names shown, and the designations used on this map do not imply official endorsement or acceptance by the United Nations.

ARRIVALS AND DISPLACED POPULATIONS: KEY FIGURES AND TRENDS

UKRAINE SITUATION

8,229,379 refugees from Ukraine were recorded across Europe as of end March 2023, and over 5 million refugees had registered for temporary protection or similar national protection schemes in Europe¹. An estimated 5.3 million people were displaced inside Ukraine in January, a decrease of 600,000 from the previous month².

MEDITERRANEAN AND NORTHWEST AFRICAN MARITIME ROUTES

15,700 refugees and migrants arrived in Europe via the three Mediterranean and Northwest African maritime routes in March 2023, a 27 per cent increase compared to the previous month. As of 31 March, 394 people have been reported dead or missing along the three Mediterranean and the Northwest African maritime routes.

SOUTH EASTERN EUROPE

2,000 people have arrived in or transited through the subregion so far in March 2023, 123 per cent more than the previous month and 13 per cent more than in March 2022.

TÜRKİYE

Türkiye hosts the world's largest refugee population with over **3.6 million** Syrians under temporary protection and over 318,000 refugees and asylum-seekers under international protection.

1. Operational Data Portal: Situation Ukraine Refugee Situation. Available at: <https://data.unhcr.org/en/situations/ukraine> (Accessed: 03 April 2023).

2. IOM Displacement Tracking Matrix. Available at: <https://dtm.iom.int/ukraine> IOM Displacement Tracking Matrix. Available at: <https://dtm.iom.int/ukraine> (Accessed: 03 April 2023).

UKRAINE RESPONSE

- Intense fighting continued in Donetsk oblast throughout March, particularly around the towns of Avdiivka and Bakhmut. To address the consequences of disruptions in critical services, UNHCR continues prioritizing life-saving humanitarian assistance and interventions. UNHCR complements and reinforces the capacity of national and local systems through timely provision of legal aid, child protection, non-food items, emergency shelter and housing support, which is intended to enable internally displaced people (IDPs) and returnees to recover and attain durable solutions, where possible.
- On the margins of UNHCR's 86th meeting of the Standing Committee in Geneva, a side event on the role of national and local NGOs as frontline actors was organized by UNHCR, the International Council of Voluntary Agencies (ICVA) and the Delegation of the EU to the UN. Drawing on an [initial rapid assessment report](#) commissioned by UNHCR and ICVA in 2022, the event highlighted experiences of local actors in the refugee response. The panel featured the refugee-led organization National Congress of Ukrainians of Moldova and the [Polish Migration Forum](#). Panel members shared information on their roles in the response and provided recommendations on how to strengthen support for local actors. UNHCR [stressed](#) the critical role that national and local organizations play in protecting and assisting refugees.

UKRAINE

221,331 people inside Ukraine supported with essential items in 2023.

REGIONAL

+55,000 refugees from Ukraine were reached through 32 Blue Dot hubs in 2023.*

* Information on reach is gathered from data provided by 32 Blue Dot hubs in Bulgaria, Hungary, Poland, Romania, Slovakia, Slovenia and the Republic of Moldova

UNHCR 2023 TARGETS IN UKRAINE



*A number of recipients are anticipated to benefit from multiple forms of support and assistance.



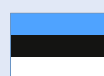
Following the global launch of the [2023 Ukraine Situation Regional Refugee Response Plan \(RRP\)](#), RRP country chapters for 11 countries were published throughout March. Country chapters present critical overviews of needs and risks faced by refugees from Ukraine, while proposing context-specific strategies to meet them.



BULGARIA



CZECH
REPUBLIC



ESTONIA



HUNGARY



LATVIA



LITHUANIA



POLAND



REPUBLIC OF
MOLDOVA



ROMANIA



SLOVAKIA

EMERGENCY RESPONSE EARTHQUAKES IN TÜRKİYE

- The UN High Commissioner for Refugees, Filippo Grandi, [visited Türkiye](#) from 10 - 12 March to express solidarity with the Government, refugees, and the Turkish people, and urge for further support to survivors. The HC called on countries accepting refugees to accelerate resettlement procedures as a responsibility-sharing mechanism and manifestation of robust international solidarity.
- In support of the national response to the needs of earthquake-affected people, UNHCR continued with the delivery of core relief items (CRIs), reaching authorities with 557,500 CRIs and 32,000 tents since the February earthquakes. In provinces neighbouring affected areas, UNHCR worked with local authorities to identify challenges faced by earthquake affected people. Meanwhile partners in Gaziantep, Hatay, Kilis, Malatya and Şanlıurfa gradually resumed legal and psychological counselling sessions for refugees and asylum-seekers, including on documentation, family reunification, and exit and re-entry procedures.

ASYLUM AND PROTECTION

- **Belgium:** On 23 March, UNHCR brought the global law firm DLA Piper together with representatives from 10 refugee-led committees in Brussels to encourage information sharing and raise awareness on DLA Piper's "Know your Rights" project. The programme provides legal education training for refugees and asylum-seekers to help them better understand their rights. The 10 refugee-led committees in Brussels, supported by UNHCR include [Rainbow Refugee](#), the Umbrella Refugee Committee and Women's Refugee Committees. DLA Piper will provide training on key issues such as housing, employment, health-related issues, and women's rights on community centre premises.
- **France:** Between 13 - 14 March, UNHCR met with associations supporting forcibly displaced people living in Calais to finalize discussions with [Secours Catholique France Terre d'Asile](#), [Audasse](#), [La Vie Active](#) regarding the initiation of the UNHCR-led data gathering of displaced people in the region. Participants will utilize two UNHCR questionnaires, one of which is tailored to identifying the needs of unaccompanied minors, focusing primarily on access to child protection services. In May, UNHCR will gather data pertaining to the profiles, needs, and backgrounds of displaced people in Calais to identify appropriate solutions and foster a deeper understanding of their plight.
- **UK:** On 23 March, UNHCR published [legal observations](#) on the proposed Illegal Migration Bill, noting its enactment is likely to have a detrimental impact on the international refugee protection system. Additionally, UNHCR provided [factsheets](#) on the Illegal Migration Bill, including information on safe and regular routes to the UK for asylum-seekers, arrivals over the Channel, and other predicted challenges stemming from the Bill. UNHCR also shared [a statement](#) expressing concern regarding the Bill and its possible impact on people seeking asylum.

EDUCATION

- **Russian Federation:** On 21 March, UNHCR visited the First Moscow State Medical University and the College of Business and Design in Moscow, who host two first-year DAFI ([Albert Einstein German Academic Refugee Initiative](#)) scholarship-holders from Afghanistan. During the visit, UNHCR provided information on its support to enrolled refugee students. Since 1994, more than 200 refugee students from Afghanistan, Angola, Iran, Somalia, Syria, Ukraine, Uzbekistan and Yemen have benefitted from the DAFI scholarship in the Russian Federation.

INCLUSION

- **Croatia:** On 24 and 31 March, UNHCR in collaboration with partner Festival of Tolerance hosted a sensitization event for 200 secondary school children in Kutina and Varaždin cities. The event aimed to support the civic education program, which seeks to foster an inclusive and informed society. During the event, UNHCR partner Jesuit Refugee Service provided an overview of their work assisting refugees to improve awareness amongst students. During the event, UNHCR supplied students with virtual reality headsets to simulate the experiences of refugees in camp settings. Students also had the opportunity to meet with a refugee-peer from Syria and ask her questions about her personal journey arriving to Croatia.
- **Georgia:** On 15 March, in line with UNHCR advocacy, [Georgia joined the European Qualifications Passport for Refugees](#) (EQPR), which [helps](#) refugees whose education and professional qualifications were disrupted by conflict or persecution to have their skills recognized in a transparent and fair manner by Council of Europe member states. Georgia is now the 22nd partner country to promote the EQPR as a practical tool for better integration of refugees in their new communities.
- **Italy:** UNHCR signed a protocol with [Naples Municipality](#) to promote refugee access to local services. This comes one month after UNHCR signed a similar protocol with the Municipality of [Bari](#). The protocol includes the establishment of a versatile centre ('Spazio Comune') providing administrative, housing, and employment support. ActionAid International collaborates with UNHCR on this effort. Naples, a signatory of [UNHCR's Integration Charter](#), has actively participated in projects promoting social and work integration, including the [Community Matching](#) and Welcome initiatives.

STATELESSNESS

- **Armenia:** On 22 March, UNHCR organized the first quarterly [Working Group on Statelessness meeting](#) of 2023, bringing together NGOs, legal experts and academia cooperating in the framework of UNHCR's [#IBELONG](#) campaign with Armenia's newly created [Migration and Citizenship Service](#). Government representatives briefed attendees on a draft Law on Foreigners and Stateless Persons and statistical analysis on statelessness, in line with [pledges](#) made during UNHCR's 2019 High-Level Segment (HLS) on eliminating statelessness. Stakeholders also examined achievements, gaps and ways forward, including building on the joint efforts of UNHCR and the Statistical Committee of Armenia (ArmStat) on identification and data collection of stateless persons.



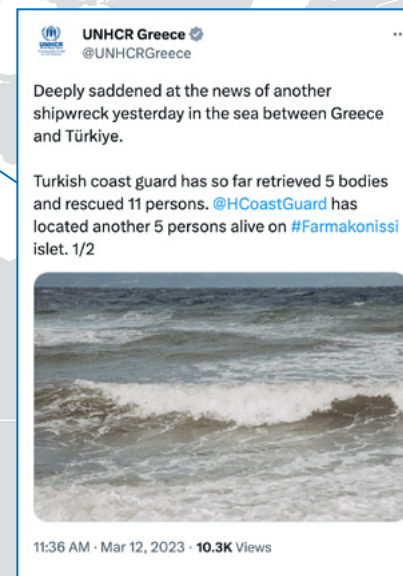
UNHCR won the 'Best Impact Project Award' for its pilot project using blockchain technology to disburse cash to people displaced by the war in Ukraine.
© UNHCR/Celine Schmitt

UNHCR wins 2023 Paris Blockchain Week Award

The 2023 Paris Blockchain Week awarded UNHCR its "Best Impact Project Award" for a pilot project using blockchain technology to disburse cash to people in Ukraine. Since this award singles out projects delivering significant social impact using blockchain technology, it acknowledged UNHCR's commitment to explore innovative solutions to assist refugees and other forcibly displaced people. As the number of people forced to flee and humanitarian crises across the world increases, UNHCR aims to harness new technologies to further assist people.

EUROPE MEDIA HIGHLIGHTS

COUNTRY OFFICE TWITTER HIGHLIGHTS



PRESS RELEASES, STATEMENTS

Press Release [4 MAR]
UNHCR, IOM welcome Spain's expedited resettlement of Syrian refugees from Türkiye in earthquake aftermath

Press Release [13 MAR]
Visiting earthquake-ravaged areas of Türkiye and Syria, UNHCR's Grandi urges more support for survivors trying to rebuild

Press Release [21 MAR]
AU, EU and UN push for urgent action to address the pressing needs of migrants and refugees in Libya

Press Release [23 MAR]
UNHCR wins award for innovative use of blockchain solutions to provide cash to forcibly displaced in Ukraine

LEADERSHIP ACCOUNT TWEETS

Filippo Grandi, UN High Commissioner for Refugees: High Commissioner concludes 5-day visit to earthquake-devastated areas of Syria and Türkiye in need of urgent humanitarian aid. [12 MAR]

Gillian Triggs, Assistant High Commissioner for Protection: Asylum bill introduced by the UK Government to the House of Commons would deny access to asylum and protection and be a clear breach of the Refugee Convention. [7 MAR]

Christoph Pinter, UNHCR Austria Head of Office: Over 13,000 unaccompanied minors applied for asylum in Austria in 2022. However, only 2,300 of them were in basic care by the end of 2022. [28 MAR]

Francesca Bonelli, UNHCR Representative in the Republic of Moldova: Thanks to the People of Japan for support in delivering much-needed equipment to the Association of People with Disabilities. [31 MAR]

TOP NEWS STORIES

Al Arabiya [4 MAR]
UN urges resettlement of quake-hit Syrian refugees in Turkey

Euronews [5 MAR]
Ministers from five Mediterranean countries push for more EU solidarity on voluntary relocation initiative

BBC [8 MAR]
Asylum plan 'very concerning' and would break international law - UN Refugee Agency

Reuters [17 MAR]
Denmark deems Syrian province safe for returning refugees, worrying UNHCR

People [23 MAR]
Prince William spends time with Ukrainian refugees in Poland after sombre tribute to war dead

STORY SPOTLIGHT

A stone's throw from the European Parliament in Brussels, what was once an anonymous office building is now a vibrant community centre run by refugees. Inside, around a table in an improvised office, refugees are discussing a range of policy initiatives, including access to housing, with counterparts from the Brussels Region and UNHCR.

This partnership between the local government and refugee communities did not happen overnight. Rather, it's the outcome of a pioneering and ever-evolving project on refugee governance, which began in 2019 as part of UNHCR's work to put refugee voices at the heart of any government decision-making that would impact them. The result was the creation of the first ever refugee committee in Belgium, led by LGBTIQ+ refugees.

Ahmad Wali has been part of the refugee governance project since the very beginning and is now also President of the Umbrella Refugee Committee, which brings together all the committees and represents them in discussions with the local authorities. [Link](#)

For more stories and highlights, [subscribe to our mailing list](#).



From left to right: Alina Kokhanko, refugee from Ukraine and President of the Ukrainian Voices Refugee Committee, Ahmad Wali Ahmad Yar, a former refugee from Afghanistan, PhD researcher at the Vrije Universiteit Brussel and President of the Umbrella Refugee Committee and Alphonse Munyaneza, UNHCR's Senior Community-Based Protection Officer. © UNHCR/Nina Daeleman

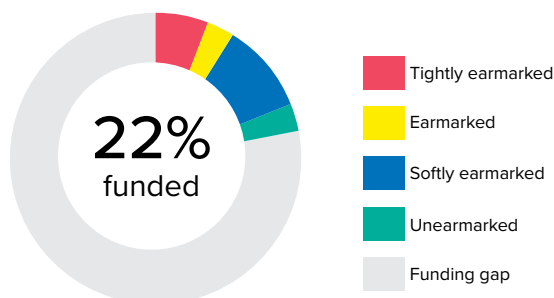
FINANCIAL INFORMATION

Requested for UNHCR's activities in Europe in 2023:

USD 1.694 billion*

Total contributed as of 28 March:

USD 365.2 million



*This amount includes financial requirements for the Ukraine situation.

WHERE TO FIND

For more information, reports and other resources:

- [UNHCR Europe webpage](#)
- [UNHCR Europe region monthly updates](#)
- [UNHCR Europe country operations fact sheets](#)
- [Europe pages of UNHCR's Global Focus webpage](#)
- [UNHCR Ukraine Emergency webpage](#)

Operational data portals:

- [Ukraine Refugee Situation](#)
- [Mediterranean Situation](#)

UNHCR is grateful for the support from our top government donors of unearmarked, softly earmarked and earmarked funding:

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We are also grateful for the generous contributions from private individuals and the private sector.